

Haywards Heath



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF AMINATTA FORNA

Aminatta Forna was born in Bellshill, Lanarkshire, Scotland, to Doctor Mohamed Sorie Forna, a Sierra Leonean man, and Maureen Christison, a Scottish woman. During her childhood, Forna's family lived in Sierra Leone where her father worked as a physician and politician, but when her parents divorced, she and her two siblings moved to the UK with their mother for a time. Eventually, her father gained custody, and he and the children returned to Sierra Leone. Due to Sierra Leone's chaotic and corrupt political state, Forna's father was the victim of a political execution. His second wife brought his children out of the country to live in England. There, Forna studied law at University College London. She went on to work as a reporter and documentarian, focusing on African life. She went on to write many novels and now works as a Professor of Creative Writing at Bath Spa University.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Although its presence is rather subtle in "Haywards Heath," Forna's story is undoubtedly influenced by Western colonialism and imperialism in Africa, along with the Black Rights Movement of the 1960s. From the 15th century to the 19th century, the Atlantic slave trade brought enslaved African people to the Americas and Europe. Later, in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, Western powers vied for imperial control over parts of Africa. This slave trade and subsequent movement of imperialism led to deep trauma in the African population and displaced many African peoples (in "Haywards Heath," Attila mentions this subject as his area of expertise). The fight for racial equality lasted long after such imperialism lessened, however. From 1954 to 1968, civil rights activists fought against racial segregation, discrimination, and voter disqualification across the country. While laws were put in place that lessened legal discrimination, racism persisted, and the Black power movement, largely formed based on Malcolm X's ideologies, rose in protest of the lack of true justice. Despite these movements and the many steps made towards progress, racial gaps still exist in income, education, and criminal justice.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Much of Forna's work revolves around similar themes as "Haywards Heath," such as interpersonal relationships, memory, and cultural histories. Her novel *Happiness* is one such work, exploring the relationship between an American woman and Ghanaian man who meet each other by chance in London and develop a strong bond over the course of the story. Other

than Forna's work, many contemporary authors also tackle similar themes. Alice Munro's short story "The Bear Came Over the Mountain" follows a husband in the aftermath of his wife's Alzheimer's diagnosis; Munro explores the ways aging and disease affects the husband and wife individually as well as how it affects their relationship. Additionally, Wallace Stegner's *The Spectator Bird* follows a protagonist returning to a significant place in his past (just as Attila does in "Haywards Heath") in order to come to terms with a part of his history. Finally, Paule Marshall's *Praisesong for the Widow* follows an African American woman as she reconciles with her husband's death as well as her ancestry, sharing Forna's exploration of race and cultural identity.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Haywards Heath
- **When Published:** 2010
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Short Story, Literary Fiction
- **Setting:** Haywards Heath, England
- **Climax:** Attila watches Rosie and her nurse share a dance.
- **Antagonist:** The passage of time
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Outreach. Forna founded the Rogbonko Village Project in December of 2002 to help spread resources to a small village in Sierra Leone.



PLOT SUMMARY

Attila, a middle-aged doctor, is startled by the radio in his rental car. Given his plans, he was already on edge, but this has only made it worse. He assumes it was the young clerk who left the radio on, and once he finds something better to listen to, he begins to relax. As he begins his journey towards Haywards Heath, he reflects on an inside joke between himself and his former lover, Rosie. Rosie, a Haywards Heath native, would ask the international students to try to pronounce the name of her hometown, which they always struggled with. Attila was one of these international students, and it was over this topic of conversation that they first connected over dinner. After meeting in their third year of medical school, the two became a couple for the remaining three years, until Attila had to move back to his home country following graduation. His plans for visiting Rosie began when a colleague at a hospital in London

mentioned that she had taken an “early retirement.” From then on, his plans to see her after four decades consumed him.

Attila stops at a pub for something to eat in the middle of his journey. When he asks the pub’s manager for directions, the manager tells him it would be much easier to use GPS. Although Attila is reluctant to stop using his atlas and even defies the GPS’s directions in an attempt to trick it, he still uses it to get him to Haywards Heath. There, he finds Rosie’s retirement home. The nurses point him to the day room, where Rosie sits by the window. As they greet each other, Attila reflects on the end of their relationship; Rosie wanted him to stay in England, but because of his status as an international student, he insisted that he return to his home country.

As they talk, Attila comes to realize that Rosie’s memory has deteriorated. She remembers the younger version of Attila but does not recognize the man visiting her. This discovery overwhelms Attila, and he must take a moment to himself in the bathroom to calm down. On his way back to Rosie, he sees a male African nurse attentively caring for another resident. They make eye contact and part ways. Attila and Rosie then take a turn in the garden, continuing to make small talk about the **birds** and Haywards Heath. Though Rosie has grown older, Attila still finds her just as beautiful as he did 40 years ago. Before he leaves, Rosie asks him if he will visit her again, and he promises he will.

Two months later, he returns with **Rosie’s favorite candies**. He finds her taking part in an afternoon dance in the dining room. She dances with the African nurse he saw during his last visit, who, he now notes, resembles a younger version of himself. After the song ends, Rosie asks the nurse to do “another turn, Attila.” The nurse agrees, and Attila sits at a table and watches the two dance.

that Rosie remembers. He watches as they dance, content as long as Rosie is happy.

Rosie – Rosie is Attila’s former lover who was sent into early retirement due to her deteriorating memory. She was born in Haywards Heath, the town she is now retired in, and met Attila during their third year of medical school. While she desperately wanted him to stay in England with her following their graduation, his scholarship stipulated that he return home. In the time between their relationship and her retirement, Rosie doesn’t reach out, not even when Attila’s wife dies. When Attila visits her, she does not recognize him as her former lover; she only remembers the younger version of him and seemingly thinks of herself as more youthful than she is. During their visit, she is easily distracted and speaks little of her current situation. When he visits again at Rosie’s request, she is dancing with a young male nurse, thinking he is a young Attila. She requests another dance, and the nurse agrees. Rosie happily continues dancing as Attila watches from afar.

Young Male Nurse – The young male nurse is an African nurse at Rosie’s retirement home who resembles a young Attila. He is caring and attentive to his patients, and he even partners with Rosie during an afternoon dance. During this dance, she mistakenly thinks him to be a young Attila; when she asks that they continue dancing, he agrees, saying that he will do anything to make her happy.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don’t have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



CHARACTERS

Attila – Attila is the middle-aged protagonist. He was an international medical student in England where he met his longtime lover, Rosie. While they stayed together for the latter half of their college years, he left their relationship behind to return to his home country following graduation. Decades later, while working as a visiting consultant for a London hospital, he learns of Rosie’s early retirement and decides that he will visit her. When he does, he is distressed to realize that her memory has deteriorated, and though she remembers a younger version of Attila, she does not recognize the man who is visiting her. As he takes her for a walk in the retirement home’s garden, he reminisces on their relationship, feeling “bizarrely [...] youthful” thanks to Rosie’s girlish mood. When he leaves, Rosie asks if he’ll visit her again, and Attila swears he will. True to his word, Attila returns two months later. He finds Rosie dancing with a young male nurse, who resembles the version of Attila



THE PASSAGE OF TIME

“Haywards Heath” presents the passage of time as an impossibly strong force that cannot be stopped, no matter how someone might try to resist it. It centers on a middle-aged man, Attila, visiting his old lover, Rosie, in her retirement home. Even before his trip to see her truly gets underway, the changes caused by the passage of time are made clear. When his rental car’s radio startles him when he starts the car, Attila notes that “the new generation could not tolerate the sound of silence.” Already, he draws a line between past and present generations, highlighting change over time and suggesting the younger generation is lacking compared to his own. A similar shift is shown in how Attila tries to find his way to Rosie’s retirement home. For the first part of his journey, he uses a physical atlas, but, after asking a pub keeper for directions, he’s told it would be better to use satnav. Even when Attila does so, he purposefully makes wrong turns

to see if he can trick the automated voice, but it “unflappably” redirects him to the correct route. He tries, both in using an atlas and in trying to trick his GPS, to prove the “old” ways of navigating are still just as effective, but contemporary innovations appear relatively foolproof.

These more banal examples of the passage of time parallel how time has indelibly impacted Attila and Rosie’s relationship, despite Attila’s efforts to reconcile with her. When Attila finally comes face to face with Rosie after decades of not seeing her, it becomes clear that her memory has deteriorated; though she remembers having a friend named Attila who is going to visit her, she does not realize that Attila is, in fact, the one visiting her now. Two months later, when he comes to visit her again, she thinks a young nurse who has similar features to Attila is a younger Attila. Not only has the passage of time affected Rosie so that her mind and memory betray her, but it has also changed Attila so that, in her deteriorating state, Rosie can’t recognize him as the young man she once knew. Despite Attila’s efforts to reconcile with Rosie after their years apart, then, time has already taken an irreversible toll. Altogether, through Attila’s efforts to reunite with Rosie, the story suggests that yearning for the past is something of a fool’s errand—that the passage of time is, in the end, impossible to resist.



MIND AND BODY

Though “Haywards Heath” depicts the mind and the body as firmly connected in many ways, the story also suggests that they can just as easily

become disconnected. The connection between the mind and body is made clear in the story’s opening paragraph. As Attila is startled by the car radio, “his heart beat[s] wildly, and his scalp [...shrinks] against his skull, hair follicles tightened in alarm.” This description is incredibly visceral and stands out in its emphasis on the body. Here, Attila’s psychology is directly and intrinsically connected to his body. His fear affects even his hair follicles, however small and distinct they might be from his psyche. Even more significantly, when he first hears of Rosie’s early retirement, he recalls that “he had exhaled all the breath in his lungs at the sound of her name.” His memory of this vital moment is intertwined with his physical reaction, his lengthy exhale. Later, he distinctly remembers this bodily reaction, showing how his mind and memory are tied to his physical body. This connection between mind and body is not present in the same way for Rosie, however. While the narration never allows readers directly inside her perspective, it seems likely that she mentally envisions herself to be younger than she really is; this is hinted at by her being unable to understand that she is in a retirement home and by her connection to the nurse who resembles a *young* Attila. Her deteriorating mind, one that assumes a sense of youthfulness, and her aging body are thus disconnected in a significant way. This dissonance between Attila and Rosie does not imply that the experience of one is

more valid than the other; however, the story does use the imbalance between their experiences, and the obstacle this becomes for their relationship, to suggest that the connection between mind and body is incredibly fragile, its decline a sad but inevitable part of being human.



RACE AND IDENTITY

Race, though never explicitly discussed, underlies the story in its entirety, an intentional choice that allows the author to comment on the experience of a non-White character. Attila’s race is never stated by the narrator, but certain lines strongly imply that he is Black. For one, he’s described as an international student during his time in university in London. Later, it’s said that, as a student, he “wore a Malcolm X goatee” to his lectures, which hints at an affinity with the Black empowerment movement. Furthermore, he notes that a nurse at Rosie’s retirement home is “black herself,” implying Attila is also Black, and he often identifies with another male African nurse. These mentions of race are clearly intentional, even if they play an understated role in the plot. Rosie’s race is never mentioned or implied, so assuming that their relationship ended because of race (apart from the fact that Attila’s nationality was a reason for his move away from England) would be a stretch. However, that doesn’t mean Attila’s racial identity is unimportant. The relative subtlety of the author’s exploration of race is exactly the point. Attila’s race is an intrinsic part of his identity and consciousness that shapes his day-to-day life, even if only in small ways that may not always be obvious to the reader. In depicting Attila’s relationship with race in this way, Forna suggests that even if its impact is not always overt, race is deeply entwined with personal identity.



LOVE

Although it’s been decades since Attila and Rosie have seen each other and many external factors are working against them, the love they still have for each other is strikingly evident. As soon as Attila hears of Rosie’s early retirement, “the idea for the trip came to him [...] and [took] over.” Even so long after their relationship ended, Attila cares enough about Rosie to become entirely “consumed” by his need to see her. Similarly, despite her memory stopping Rosie from recognizing Attila in the present day, the memory she has of her youthful lover is incredibly fond. When she talks about her “friend” who is coming to visit, she explains how “[she’s] waiting for him.” Later, when she dances with the nurse thinking he is Attila, she “presse[s] [her forehead] against his chest,” and asks him, “Shall we do another turn, Attila? Another turn. What do you say?” This phrase is significant because it is one she used to say during their relationship. These excerpts show that, while Rosie’s mind only remembers a much younger Attila, the love she has for him remains strong. Not only that,

but Attila's love for Rosie is further demonstrated by his response to her interaction with the male nurse; instead of leaving or intervening, he sits and watches, because, as the nurse says to Rosie, Attila wants "whatever makes [her] happy," even if that means he has to be a part of her life from afar. Attila's love for Rosie perseveres because he only wants what's best for her, regardless of what he might selfishly want. The story thus suggests that the strongest love is one that respects the beloved's wants and needs and that such a love can persist even through the most tumultuous of changes—even if it is not meaningfully reciprocated.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



BIRDS

Throughout the story, birds symbolize hope and resilience amid change. The variety of birds come to represent the many different ways such resilience can look. The first instance of a bird is when Attila first greets Rosie at her retirement home. Outside, he sees another resident "[throwing] crumbs for a lone blackbird" while sitting next to her daughter. This rather melancholy moment hints at how constricted Rosie's own life may have become, though the fact that the resident feeds the bird suggests that even a narrower existence need not lack for meaning and connection. Later, Rosie herself mentions two types of birds in the garden; as she's walking with Attila, she says, "People say you can't have two robins in the same garden, but there's no truth in it. Look! [...] A wren." Even in her changed and apparently reduced circumstances, Rosie continues to notice and take delight in simple details like everyday birds in a garden, reflecting both the tragedy of her memory loss and her resilience in the midst of it. Without denying the hardships of age, the presence of birds in the story suggests that hope persists if people are willing to look for it.



BOX OF CANDIES

The box of candies Attila brings Rosie during his second visit symbolizes how the passage of time affects relationships on the surface but doesn't necessarily change them at their core. As they walk in the garden, Rosie swipes a candy from another resident's stash, telling Attila that "they're [her] favorite." When he returns two months later, he brings a box of those same candies, though he says that "the packaging had changed, as might be expected after forty years." Presumably, the candy inside has stayed the same, at least enough for Rosie to recognize them as a favorite of her youth,

yet, after 40 years, the box of candy looks different on the outside. Attila and Rosie's relationship is similar: while time has changed both of them, to the extent that Rosie doesn't even recognize Attila, their love for each other perseveres. Of course, the ways they've changed over the decades are more profound than the change in the candies' packaging, which underscores the persistence of their love for each other, even though their relationship will no longer look the same on the outside.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Oxford University Press edition of *Stories of Ourselves: Volume 2* published in 2018.

Haywards Heath Quotes

☞ The youth at the car-hire desk must have turned on the radio when he brought the car round. The new generation could not tolerate the sound of silence.

Related Characters: Attila

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 430

Explanation and Analysis

This excerpt occurs early in the story as Attila is about to start his journey to Haywards Heath. It acts as a foundation for Forna's exploration of the passage of time. Firstly, Attila refers to the young clerk as "the youth." This diction defines the clerk entirely by his age and, by comparison, reveals the gap between his age and Attila's. Already, age and time are put at the forefront of readers' minds.

This emphasis on age and time is furthered by the following line, in which Attila critiques the new generation's need for constant noise. There is a clear divide between this "new generation" and Attila's; in highlighting the younger generation's need for stimulation, Attila implies that the opposite is true for his generation, that his generation could be content with simple silence. The younger generation is thus defined only by their opposition to Attila's personal, social, and cultural experience—putting aside the question of whether Attila's implication is accurate. Overall, the quote introduces the idea that the passage of time inevitably brings change, and that Attila sometimes struggles to reconcile himself to these changes.

☞ He wore a Malcolm X goatee and a suit to attend lectures. This made her feel sorry for him, she said.

Related Characters: Attila, Rosie

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 430

Explanation and Analysis

These lines come in the context of Attila's reflections on his relationship with Rosie, and they provide two specific functions: firstly, to deepen readers' understanding of Attila as a character, and secondly, to complicate readers' view of Attila and Rosie's relationship. In describing his facial hair in relation to Malcolm X, an influential figure of the Black Power movement in the mid-20th century, Forna not only reveals Attila's race, but also reveals his political alignment as a young man. If he is attempting to look like such a figure, it follows that he holds a similar system of beliefs.

Additionally, the fact that he wears suits to lectures implies that he wants to be taken seriously as a student. This detail may simply show his desire to resemble Malcolm X, who was often seen in a suit and tie, but it could also suggest that Attila feels the need to prove himself a professional academic. This latter characterization is strengthened by the following line, which shares how Rosie pitied Attila's choice of dress. The fact that she feels sorry for him points to the fact that he feels he must prove himself as a Black man to be worthy of higher education.

This is, of course, left incredibly ambiguous; Forna delves no deeper into Attila's relationship with his education or how Rosie viewed him. It is in this ambiguity that Forna reveals the depths of Attila and Rosie's relationship. There are parts of their dynamic that readers are never privy to, such as why exactly Rosie feels sorry for him. The complexity of their relationship is thus developed in this ambiguity; by leaving out so many details, Forna implies that their relationship cannot be fully contained in such a compact story.

☞ Now he knew how his patients felt. He analysed his own behaviour. Prevarication. He drove steadily for ten minutes following the voice's orders.

Related Characters: Attila

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 431

Explanation and Analysis

This excerpt occurs as Attila reluctantly uses his GPS to make his way to Rosie's retirement home; as he's doing so, he purposefully defies the GPS's directions to try and trick the computer into making a mistake (though it never does). Here, too, is one of the only moments where Attila openly mentions his job, and this mention of his work both reveals elements of his career and characterizes him as analytical, intelligent, and objective, perhaps to a fault.

Attila recognizes that his behavior is problematic and can objectively conclude that he is "prevaricating," or, in other words, being intentionally deceitful in his defiance of his GPS. After this quasi-diagnosis, he changes his behavior, following the GPS's directions as they are given to him. In a short span of time, he is able to highlight his negative behavior, determine the cause, and shift his behavior to be more positive. This pattern of action reflects his daily tasks as a doctor and thus characterizes him as someone who excels in being clinical and objective.

While this objectivity helps him improve his behavior, it also points to a certain disconnect between Attila and his emotions. Not once during this excerpt does Attila reckon with the emotions that might be causing him to behave this way (such as a petty defensiveness against modern technology). Instead, he whittles his behavior down to objective facts, a phenomenon that is highlighted by this excerpt's short bursts of sentences; he quickly and concisely determines the roots of his behavior and spends no time dwelling on any deeper meaning behind it. Thus, Attila is presented as a character who is focused on objectivity rather than his emotions.

☞ The air was overheated, filled with static and the smells of cooked food and talcum powder.

Related Characters: Attila

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 431

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Attila describes his first impressions of Rosie's retirement home. While his description is not an outright critique of the nursing home, he doesn't describe it as the most enticing place to live. In fact, he presents it as a sort of

liminal space or limbo. This excerpt is vague, with the few details it does share being plain, such as that the retirement home smells simply of “cooked food.” The smell of talcum powder might be slightly more specific, but it likely applies to many, if not all, retirement homes. Finally, the fact that the air is “filled with static” further cements a sense of stagnation or a lack of energy.

In describing the retirement home in such a manner, Forna presents it as a place that is nondescript and stagnant. There is nothing that distinguishes it from other retirement homes (it’s never even given a name), and, furthermore, nothing that implies it is comfortable or homey. As such, it seemingly exists only as a space for its residents to await their death. There is no sense of leading a meaningful life in this retirement home, only a bare, unchanging existence. This reveals just how far Rosie has declined from the lively academic Attila once knew.

☞ The last time they saw each other she had not wanted him to leave. He told her it was a condition of his scholarship. They’d argued for weeks, months. ‘What about us?’ she’d pleaded. But he went back to his country anyway, full of ideas of himself, of the future. Which one of them had been naïve?

Related Characters: Attila, Rosie

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 432

Explanation and Analysis

This excerpt occurs as Attila reflects on the end of his and Rosie’s relationship. It depicts both their sides of the argument and, in doing so, shows how their characters differ. Attila reasons that their relationship must end because of the practical and logistical issues at hand—he must leave the country due to the conditions of his scholarship. He is level-headed and objective, considering only the rational facts.

Rosie, on the other hand, is more sentimental in her desire for the two to stay together. Her argument to keep Attila in England is only “What about us,” an appeal to the emotional connection they share. Where Attila is logical and focused on himself, Rosie is emotional and focused on their partnership. Still, the author does not pass judgment regarding which character is most correct in their outlook, leaving the reader to make up their own mind. By ending this excerpt with the question “Which one of them had been

naïve,” Forna gestures to the fact that both characters had valid reasons for behaving as they did and that it’s difficult, if not impossible, to claim that only one person was in the wrong.

☞ Through a porthole in a door he saw the young African helper spooning food into the mouth of an elderly woman. Something about the scene stopped Attila: the hand at her back, which prevented her from slumping, the infinite care in the way the young man wiped her slackened mouth with a napkin. At one point the careworker looked up, straight at Attila. Their eyes met. The young man said nothing but bent once more to his task. Attila turned away.

Related Characters: Attila, Young Male Nurse

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 432

Explanation and Analysis

After discovering Rosie’s deteriorating memory, Attila calms himself in the bathroom and, on his way back to the day room, catches sight of the young male nurse caring for another resident. This gives Attila pause, but the reason for this pause is never made entirely clear. In part, it seems to be the intense amount of care the nurse has for this resident. Attila notes how attentive and gentle he is with the resident, which may give Attila more peace about how Rosie is being treated in the retirement home.

That being said, the fact that the nurse is Black reinforces the story’s heavy implication that Attila, too, is Black. In addition, the fact that the two men’s eyes meet appears to be a moment of shared recognition, albeit an understated one—presumably, both men are used to being one of a minority of Black people in England. There may be yet more to the glance, however, at least on Attila’s side. Watching a Black nurse spoon-feeding an (implicitly) White woman might give Attila a glimpse of what life might look like if he and Rosie were to rekindle a relationship at this stage in their lives. In other words, it would almost certainly be a relationship of caretaker and dependent rather than of lovers like they used to be.

☛ She held on to his arm, seemingly awash with the wonder of it all. She reached out to touch the drops of rain on the leaves, tilted her head, gazed at the sky and closed her eyes. He waited and watched her. She stretched out her arms. He had a memory of a photograph of her in the exact same pose. Where was it now?

Related Characters: Attila, Rosie

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 433

Explanation and Analysis

As Rosie and Attila stroll through the retirement home's garden, he admires her youthful attitude. Rosie's attitude further exhibits the state of her mental deterioration. This description of Rosie is incredibly youthful, consumed with wonder at the simple sight of raindrops on a leaf. Though the story doesn't reveal much of Rosie as a young woman, such a description gives readers insight into the extent of her ill health; she was once a successfully published academic, but she has now regressed to a girlish state of wonder.

Her regression to a more youthful version of herself is further strengthened by Attila's reference to an old photo in which Rosie held a similar pose. Subconsciously, Rosie is acting like her former self did, emphasizing the ways in which the passage of time has stolen facets of life from Attila and Rosie. This old photo is lost, as is the version of Rosie he once knew and the relationship they once shared. Though Rosie is unaware, she also faces the tragic loss of her old self.

☛ Behind them the old woman sat staring into the middle distance, her hands curled limply around the box of sweets. Attila could hear the daughter finish her call.

Related Characters: Attila, Rosie

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 433

Explanation and Analysis

This excerpt occurs as Attila and Rosie finish their walk in the garden. Attila noticed this resident and her daughter

earlier in the story, when he saw them from the dayroom window. Both moments give very few details about the mother and daughter, but, in both moments, the daughter is distracted by a phone call. This image, one of an elderly mother staring off into space while her daughter is occupied by other matters, presents a rather pessimistic view of aging. However, these characters actually function to parallel Attila's desperate desire to reconnect with Rosie.

It is after seeing this mother and daughter for the first time that Attila apologizes to Rosie; seeing the daughter who is distracted by her phone call, he recalls how he's been disconnected from Rosie and seeks to rectify that. Then, after the above excerpt where the daughter ends her phone call, Attila swears to Rosie that he will visit her again. Seeing the lack of connection between the mother and daughter seems to prompt Attila to try to do better for Rosie.

☛ Around the room elders dozed and snored, made soporific as flies by music and heat.

Related Characters: Attila, Rosie

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 434

Explanation and Analysis

Two months after his first visit, Attila returns to Rosie's retirement home and describes its dining room, which has been turned into the setting for an afternoon dance. The narrator's use of language suggests Attila's intelligence but also displays the upsetting effects of the passage of time. The use of the word "soporific" stands out, as it is not part of most people's everyday vocabulary. Though Attila does not use the word directly himself, the narrator's usage implies that Attila regularly uses elevated diction—a point that distances him from present-day Rosie.

Furthermore, by comparing the home's elderly residents to flies, Forna emphasizes how drastically time can affect the human mind and body. This metaphor displays a sense of minuteness and insignificance, as well as a lack of humanity. Not only have the residents' physical capacities weakened, but time has also led to mental deterioration that strips them of the ability to be their fullest selves. Though the narrator does not openly say that this state of affairs is tragic, the "flies" simile makes the point more powerfully by illustrating how much time can diminish people's ability to meaningfully engage with their surroundings.

●● He bent to pick up the box of sweets, heard Rosie say his name and looked up. The smile was already on his face.

But she was not looking his way, seemed not to be aware of his presence in the room. Rather she was looking up at the young careworker, who still held her in his arms. 'Shall we do another turn, Attila? Another turn. What do you say?'

And the young man replied, 'Whatever makes you happy, Rosie.'

Rosie nodded. The music began again. Attila replaced the box of Newbury Fruits on the table. He sat down and watched.

Related Characters: Attila, Rosie , Young Male Nurse

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 434

Explanation and Analysis

This section closes the story as Attila watches Rosie dance with the young nurse. The parallels drawn between Attila and the nurse cement the story's understanding of love. Rosie believes the nurse to be a younger version of Attila

and refers to him as such. The nurse doesn't discourage this line of thinking, responding that he will do anything to make her happy. Attila effectively agrees with the nurse, seeing as his only reaction to their conversation is to sit and watch the pair dance.

Additionally, he sets the box of Rosie's favorite candies aside. As they have been her favorite candies since they met, Attila's decision to set them aside for the time being shows how he knows he needs to push any previous understandings of his relationship with Rosie to the side; the woman he knew is greatly changed, and the only way he can remain in her life is to adapt into the person she needs him to be now.

While the love they still hold for each other is clear—Attila is clearly eager to connect with Rosie and give her a gift, and Rosie is clearly thinking of Attila as she dances with the nurse—their relationship can't exist as it has in the past. Attila is aware of this and, in setting their past aside and letting Rosie have a special moment with the nurse, Forna suggests that, though dynamics between people may be forced to change, even in heartbreaking ways, there is still a sense in which real love can persevere.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

HAYWARDS HEATH

Attila is startled by the loud radio as he starts his rental car, a Jaguar XJ that he got at a discount thanks to a mistake made by the car-rental staff. His anxiety is heightened by his plans for the day. He assumes that the young worker at the car-hire desk must have left the radio on as he brought it to Attila; as he puts it, “the new generation could not tolerate the sound of silence.” Slowly, Attila’s nerves lessen, and he makes his way towards Haywards Heath.

Attila’s quickness to startle emphasizes his already heightened nerves at the start of the story, and, as he goes on to confirm, this suggests that his plans have him on edge. Additionally, his assumption that the young clerk left the radio on because “the new generation could not tolerate the sound of silence” distinguishes the young generation from Attila’s generation. From this, readers can gather that Attila is at least middle-aged. His words also begin to highlight the significance of the passage of time and aging in the story.



As he turns off the main road, Attila reflects on a joke he and his former lover, Rosie, had shared about international students being unable to pronounce “Haywards Heath.” She often and teasingly asked new acquaintances to say the name of her hometown; after Attila did so, they shared weighted eye contact that was only broken by Rosie when it became too much for her. Attila knew that she was strongly affected by his gaze, though she would go on to deny it even after they had begun their “affair.” It is revealed that they met in college, where Attila wore “a Malcolm X goatee and a suit to attend lectures,” which made Rosie pity him. After meeting in their third year, they were in a relationship for three years, but this relationship ended when Attila had to return to his home country.

This flashback suggests the narrative importance of Attila and Rosie’s relationship, as she is the only other named character at this point. Additionally, Rosie asking Attila to pronounce “Haywards Heath” shows that he is an international student, though his home country isn’t specified. The fact that Rosie denies being affected by Attila’s gaze, despite his insistence otherwise, suggests a certain comfort level between the two, in that Rosie is unafraid to contradict Attila, though it could also hint at a future conflict or disconnect between the two. Furthermore, referring to their relationship as an “affair” can be read as downplaying its importance, implying as it does that the relationship is not meant to last. Attila’s choice of dress, one reflecting the style of Malcolm X, implies that he is Black and politically aligned with the Black Power movement of the mid-20th century. Finally, the fact that Attila and Rosie’s schooling lasted six years hints that they met during medical school.



Later, Attila went on to work as a visiting consultant for a hospital in London, where he learned Rosie had taken an early retirement. It was then that he decided to make this trip to visit her and was “consumed by the details” of planning his visit. In the present, he is broken out of his memories by his need to stop and eat, so he pulls into a pub and orders a meal. Afterward, he asks the pub’s manager to help him find his way to the retirement home. Though Attila prefers to use an atlas, the manager helps him set up the Jaguar’s satnav, and Attila reluctantly uses it to get to his destination.

Here, it’s revealed that Attila returns to England, at least temporarily, for his career. At this point, the story doesn’t reveal why Rosie retired early, though attentive readers might guess that this detail will prove significant later. Regardless, Attila is so motivated to see her that he is “consumed” by his desire. This diction shows how deeply he still cares for Rosie; though they haven’t seen or spoken to each other in decades, as soon as he hears of her situation, he desperately needs to see her. His interaction with the pub manager further cements his detachment from modern technology and culture. At first, he insists on using his physical atlas, a navigation tool that has faded out of use in the modern era, and is only convinced to use his rental car’s GPS when the pub manager sets it up for him. Even then, he purposefully defies the GPS to prove it incompetent. Thus, Attila is presented as a character who, on some level, actively resists modern technology and, by extension, the passage of time.



He checks in with the receptionist, who, he notes, is also Black (along with a young African nurse). Attila finds Rosie in the day room reading a newspaper and unaware of his arrival. He greets her, and they exchange some small talk. As they chat, he reflects on her beauty and the last time he saw her. They had argued about him staying in the country; he needed to leave on the “condition of his scholarship,” but she wanted him to stay to continue their relationship. He, of course, went back to his country.

Attila is further implied to be Black due to the diction specifying that the nurse is “also” Black. The beginning of his interaction with Rosie seems perfectly normal, with the two catching up over the years they’ve been apart. His enduring love for her is made even clearer by his reflections on her beauty. Subsequently, in revealing the final moments of their relationship, Attila highlights their differing outlooks on their relationship, with Attila thinking practically and logically regarding his status as an international student and Rosie remaining sentimental about their connection.



Rosie asks if Attila is married, to which he says he was, but his wife passed away. Outside, he notices a resident throwing crumbs to a **blackbird** while her daughter sits next to her taking a phone call. Attila apologizes to Rosie for leaving, and, though she accepts his apology, she goes on to ask who he is. When he tells her, she responds that she has a friend with the same name who’ll be visiting her soon: her memory is deteriorating. Attila goes to the bathroom to calm himself in the face of discovering Rosie’s mental state. He doesn’t go straight back to Rosie but instead wanders the ground floor. Here, he sees the African nurse feeding an elderly woman with extreme care. When he and the nurse make eye contact, Attila turns away and returns to Rosie.

Rosie asking about Attila’s marriage reinforces the fact that they have had little to no contact over the years. The resident feeding the blackbird is the first instance of birds appearing in the story; blackbirds are often associated with adaptation and rebirth, which gives this moment a more hopeful tone than might first appear. After Attila apologizes for leaving, the extent of Rosie’s mental deterioration is revealed. Though she knows of a friend named Attila, she doesn’t recognize him as the man before her. Attila’s subsequent panic highlights that, even if he assumed Rosie wasn’t her old self, coming to terms with the extent of her decline hits him hard. The momentary eye contact between Attila and the African nurse is subtle, and while it could be read simply as understated confirmation that Attila, too, is Black and that the two men share an awareness of being racial minorities, it could also suggest that the sight of the Black nurse tenderly feeding a patient gives Attila a glimpse of what his own potential future with Rosie might look like.



Attila proposes to take Rosie on a walk around the grounds, to which she agrees. Though he tries to ask her about her time in the retirement home, she responds only by talking about her childhood and, afterwards, by commenting on the **birds** in the garden. After they finish their first turn, Rosie says, "Shall we do another turn, Attila?"—a phrase she used to use when they were a couple. Attila agrees, feeling both uneasy and youthful. Rosie swipes a **candy** from the elderly resident sitting with her daughter and asks that Attila come visit her again. He promises he will, hoping that eventually, she will remember him.

Rosie's inability to talk about her time in the retirement home points to the severity of her decline, since she seems to be under the impression that she is still in her youth. Rosie's pointing out wrens and robins is the second instance of birds appearing in the story. Like the blackbird, these birds represent joy, courage, and resilience, suggesting that even if Rosie's future is diminished from what it was before, she is still able to find hope in it. In using a phrase she used in their former relationship, Rosie shows how, even in her ill health, she still holds memories of Attila close to her. While Attila is ambivalent about his feelings of youthfulness around Rosie, they show how reconnecting with her is deeply meaningful for him; he feels enlivened even after spending a short time with her. Rosie's youthfulness is fortified by her decision to mischievously steal candy from another resident. Attila's promise to visit Rosie again seems genuine and positive, although his hope that Rosie will eventually remember him adds melancholy to this moment—though Attila's expectations for this reunion were never made explicitly clear, it seems likely that he hoped for much more than the dim possibility that Rosie will eventually remember who he is.



Two months later, Attila returns with a box of Rosie's favorite **candies**, though the packaging has changed in the past 40 years. He finds Rosie in the dining room, where a dance is taking place. Residents and staff dance to "The Blue Danube," and Attila finds Rosie dancing with the African nurse he had seen during his last visit. He notes now that the nurse has a "small beard." Attila sits at a table and watches, looking up as Rosie says his name. She is not addressing him, however. Instead, she is addressing the African nurse, who she believes to be a young Attila. As they continue to dance, Attila sits down and watches them.

The candies Attila brings on his second visit are the same kind that Rosie stole from the other resident earlier in the story. They were her favorite in their youth, and she still recognizes them as such. Attila's emphasis on the candies' change of packaging over the past four decades once again highlights how the passage of time indiscriminately forces change, even though they still taste like the candies Rosie remembers. Even though the candies have superficially changed, in other words, they are the same on the inside—suggesting that even though Attila and Rosie have outwardly changed a great deal, some meaningful core of their love still remains. Rosie and the nurse dancing to "The Blue Danube" is significant because, as it's one of the most popular waltzes of all time, the song holds a sense of timelessness; while it was composed in the 19th century, it remains recognizable and culturally significant to this day. This timelessness reflects the everlasting nature of Attila and Rosie's love. The nurse's beard draws a parallel between himself and a younger Attila, who was said to sport a goatee, and this parallel is only cemented by Rosie's mistaken belief that she is dancing with the young Attila from her memory. In responding to Rosie's mistaken belief by sitting back and watching the pair dance, rather than interfering to correct her misapprehension, Attila places his wants below Rosie's, displaying the ultimate act of love: he will do whatever it takes to make her happy, even if that means that she will never truly remember him.





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